



U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs

Veterans Health Administration
Digital Health Office

Service Mapping Playbook

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OUTLINE

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INTRO TO THIS GUIDE

This guide was developed for DHO's purposes but is inspired by and relies heavily on the work of Amanda Krauss and her customer experience catalog team at VES. They have developed a [playbook](#) for conducting this work for a CX catalog. This document aspires to leverage that work as we lay the foundations of our practice and work with design partners across VA to build VA wide best practices.

WHAT IS SERVICE MAPPING?

When we are aiming to improve complex systems, we need to look beyond the surface level experience of the end user to understand the intricacies and nuances of the processes, systems, and data that support it. Service mapping helps us see how processes, and systems integrate to produce an experience over time and touchpoints or modalities.

A user's experience happens in their life, not in our systems. They may begin their journey by searching on their phone, put it down, then continue on a desktop at home or work. They may then walk into a physical building to continue their journey and interact with multiple people and processes before they reach their goal. Service mapping helps us see the end-to-end journey, across touchpoints, and look back-stage at the systems and processes that support it.

Visually articulating the user experience alongside the behind-the-scenes activities that enable those interactions help us identify where we can reduce friction, improve efficiency, and align digital tools to the experiences we aim to deliver.

Service mapping helps us see the big picture and identify where we can better orchestrate to optimize, reduce friction, and align digital tools to the experiences we aim to deliver.

Service mapping delivers a service blueprint, which is a visual articulation of how a business provides a service to a customer or user. "Front stage" refers to things that are visible to a user or customer, backstage represents behind the line of interaction or "backstage" and are not visible to the customer.

Frontstage

- User journey
Actions a user takes to experience a service from start to finish.
- Physical and digital touchpoints
The ways a customer interacts with a service

Backstage

- Backstage staff actions
Activities that support the service but aren't visible to the customer

- Backstage systems and processes
What supports the service, i.e. data management or software
- Metrics
How value is measured at this phase or step of the journey
- Pain points and opportunities
Evidence of struggle, friction, or opportunity to improve

BENEFITS OF A SERVICE BLUEPRINT

Service mapping delivers a visual artifact called a service blueprint. They represent a broad understanding with evidence gathered from user research, business processes, system maps, and architectural diagrams.

Creating Shared Understanding:

Blueprints provide a visual aid to help individuals gain a comprehensive understanding of intricate service processes, broken down from user actions and touchpoints to the underlying backend systems and data flows.

Identifying Pain Points and Improvement Opportunities:

Blueprints help identify areas where processes may be inefficient or where VA customers encounter challenges. This spotlight can help identify pain points and opportunities for process optimization.

Fostering Communication and Collaboration:

Service blueprints are excellent communication tools to foster shared understanding across stakeholders and teams.

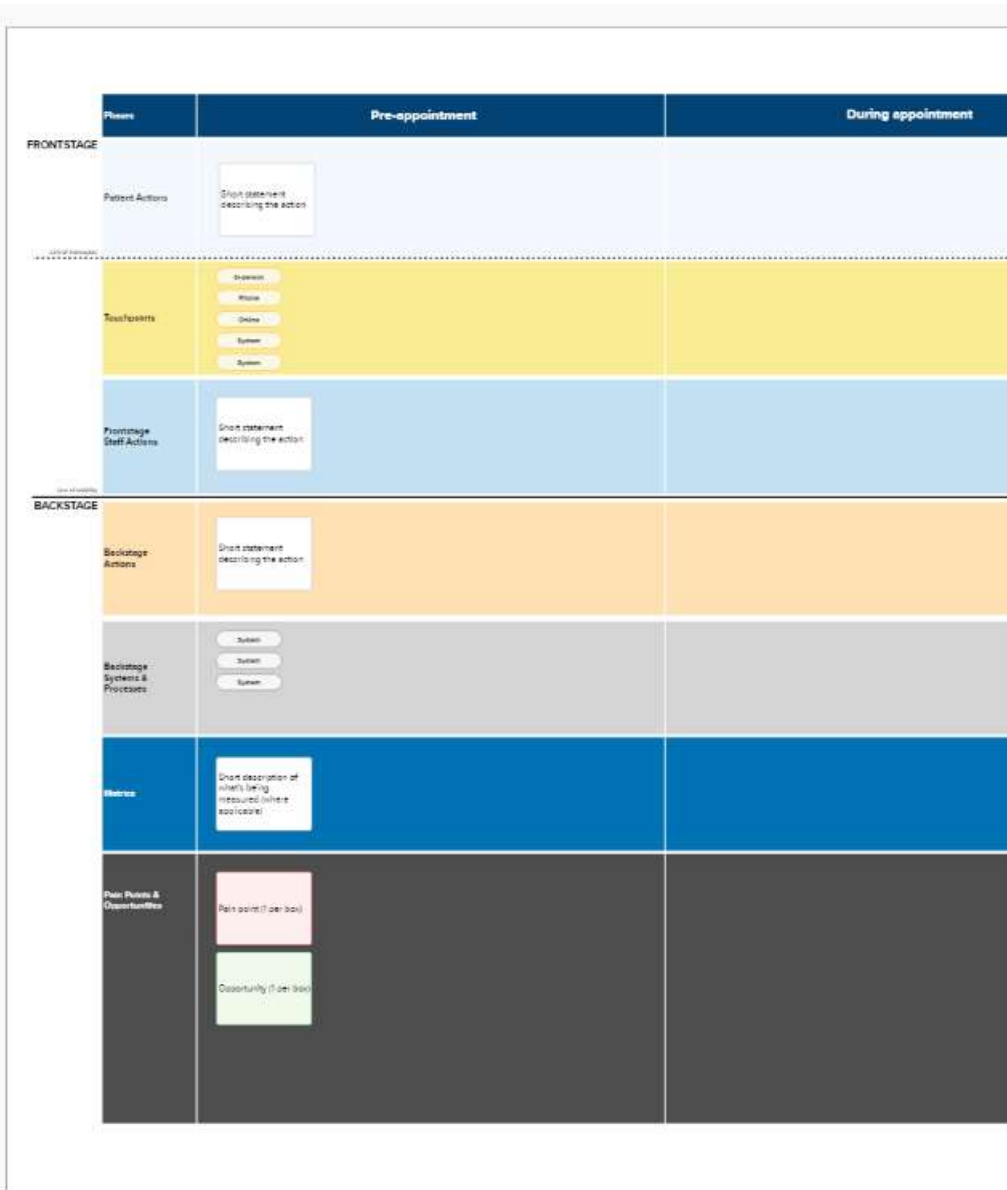
Enhancing Human-Centered Design:

Service blueprints promote user-centric approach. By mapping out the entire service journey, you can identify opportunities to align service processes with the actual needs and expectations of users.

Supporting Continuous Improvement:

Service maps, or blueprints support a culture of continuous improvement, where services can be adapted to changing user needs.

[Service map template](#), sometimes called a blueprint:



This inset view shows the phases of the journey across the top, the primary user's experience (frontstage), the staff experience (backstage), and the systems that support the experience. Metrics, pain points, and opportunities help us see places we can focus our work.



Here is a built-out example of a service blueprint for beneficiary travel, courtesy of the CX catalog team at VES.

WHEN TO INVEST IN SERVICE MAPPING

Service mapping can be applied to any journey to visualize the holistic end-to-end experience with front and backstage views. It is important to consider the problems or challenges you are addressing to scope the effort.

Guiding Questions:

- Is there a clear understanding and alignment of how things work and interact today and how they affect the user experience?
- Do teams fully understand the process?
- Are there recurring themes of frustration with the experience?

Crafting a service blueprint can help teams clarify, streamline communications through a shared visualization, and drive improvements.

SERVICE MAPPING PLAYS

PLAY 1: Define Goals and Scope

Think about who your audience is and how they will use this. It is critical to consider your audience's experience when crafting any map. Can they easily read it? Do they need to zoom in and out a lot? Can it be shared easily and serve as a reference point for collaboration?

Checklist

- ☐ Clearly define the scope of the blueprint: audience, use case, and objectives
- ☐ Define which aspects of the user journey are critical to map. Consider the typical journey but don't neglect edge cases where they may get lost.
- ☐ Identify the problem statement you are aiming to address for this blueprint. Be sure you are specific about the primary user experience you are mapping. Use this template to populate your problem statement:
I [primary user] need [feature or service] in order to [achieve desired outcome.]
- ☐ Identify success factors or metrics you're tracking for this blueprint

Key Questions:

- Why do you need this blueprint? What decisions will it support?
- What problem or challenge are we trying to address with this blueprint?
- Who is the primary audience for this blueprint, and what are their key pain points?
- What is out of scope for this effort but could be addressed later?

Tips:

1. Start with an MVP and gather continuous feedback.
2. Instead of personas, think about use cases or the jobs-to-be-done that you are targeting.
3. Communicate the scope to stakeholders and manage expectations of the blueprint.

PLAY 2: Identify Stakeholders and Existing Resources

Convene your team, including a dedicated product owner (PO), subject-matter experts, and research/designer. These experts' insights lay a strong foundation, ensure alignment and shared vision.

Checklist

- ☐ Designate a dedicated PO for the blueprint who is both familiar with the domain area and can also make decisions about scope and priority
- ☐ Identify individual(s) who may act as SMEs for the product/experience. This may be an internal team member, outside expert, or the PO.
- ☐ Ensure the PO has a clear understanding of your goals for this blueprint
- ☐ Establish dedicated touchpoints throughout development between the blueprint development team and the PO, as well as with SMEs.
- ☐ Identify existing resources: identify user research for known pain points, gaps, and opportunities. Search qualitative studies as well as survey data. Gather all existing

documentation - often there will be existing artifacts such as journey maps or architecture diagrams that will facilitate progress and help avoid re-inventing the wheel.

Key Questions

- Who will make decisions around blueprint scope and priority?
- Does the PO have a solid grasp of the intended outcomes?
- Who are the SMEs that will support blueprint development?
- What are the existing artifacts and documentation related to this customer experience?

Tips

1. To ensure that you've found the right person with the appropriate responsibilities for your blueprinting project, take a look at the Product Owner Checklist for guidance

PLAY 3: Map the High-Level User Journey

As the blueprint's focus sharpens in Play #1, Play #3 takes it a step further by visualizing the high-level user journey. This visualization becomes the canvas upon which detailed blueprints will be painted. It aligns the blueprint's scope with the overarching user experience.

Checklist:

- ☐ Create a high-level visualization of the user journey, highlighting key start and end points
- ☐ Identify critical touchpoints and interactions along the journey

Key Questions:

- What are the main stages in the user journey for this service?
- Which interactions are most significant for users and the organization to have a deeper understanding of?

Tips & Resources:

1. If you're looking to tackle a broad CX area (e.g. "Appointments"), now is the time to break this out into more discrete segments, such as: Schedule, Attend, Cancel, Reschedule. This high-level user journey can serve as a reference point.
2. Don't get too bogged down in the details of mapping out the high-level journey. The purpose of this exercise is to break down the broader journey into more manageable sub-journeys, which will serve as candidates for your detailed service blueprints.

Play 4: Identify and Inventory Blueprint Components

With the user journey map complete, the focus shifts to the infrastructure that supports it. This stage comprehensively inventories the components, or foundational building blocks, that shape the service experience, including: Veteran-facing applications, VA tools, and backend systems.

These components will ultimately bridge the gap between the high-level user journey and the nitty-gritty details of system and application interactions.

Checklist:

- ☐ Create the framework for your CX blueprint. Make sure to separate “frontstage” and “backstage” sections to indicate what is visible to end users (frontstage), and what is not visible (backstage) 8
- ☐ Inventory all of the components that will fall on the Y-axis of your blueprint, such as:
 - ☐ User-facing applications and experiences (both digital and analog)
 - ☐ Internal staff/groups that support this experience
 - ☐ Internal applications that are used by staff
 - ☐ Backend systems that support this experience
- ☐ Keep track of any components that may change - either because they are being phased out, or because they are set to launch

Key Questions:

- What are all the digital applications and interfaces available to a Veteran to navigate this experience? Are there non-digital, or analog, methods they could also use, such as a phone call or in-person conversation?
- What are the primary backstage components that need to be considered in this blueprint?
- Are there experiences/systems that are being phased out?
- Are there new experiences/systems that will soon be introduced?

Tips & Resources:

1. Not sure how to begin? Use this blueprint template as a visual starting point for the framework of your blueprint. It’s important to note that the choice of tools for your blueprinting journey is flexible. Whether you prefer other digital platforms, analog methods, or other software applications, feel free to adapt the template to suit your team’s workflow. While this template was built in FigJam, you can use any tool (both digital and analog!) to create your blueprint.
2. This component library includes a list of some digital modalities and systems that support many Veteran experiences. Use this to get started, but remember that the CX blueprint you’re working on might include apps & systems that aren’t listed in the library!

Play 5: Identify and Map System Processes

Connects the dots between the blueprint components next. Delve into the intricate web of connections and interactions, ensuring that all the components work together seamlessly to deliver the user experience. The system diagram developed in this stage also serves as the backbone for blueprint refinement in subsequent plays.

Checklist:

- ☐ Map out the connections and interactions between the identified blueprint components
- ☐ Define the flow of data and processes, specifying what data is collected, processed, and shared
- ☐ Identify the key integrations between systems and applications
- ☐ Document the dependencies between components and systems to identify their impact on service delivery
- ☐ Document pain points and other important insights that might be important to the story you're telling with the blueprint
- ☐ Validate the interaction mapping with your PO and SMEs to ensure accuracy

Key Questions:

- How do the different components of the service interact with each other to deliver the current state user experience?
- What data flows and processes connect these components?

Tips & Resources:

1. Start by leveraging your ecosystem to locate existing resources. Most of the times, teams have created system, process, and architectural maps. Leveraging these resources, map out the technical and system interactions first.
2. Create a basic system diagram that outlines how different components and systems interact. Focusing on this foundation early helps prevent unnecessary revisions to the blueprint's component connections down the line.
3. Collaborate with technical experts who can provide insights into the intricacies of system interactions. Their expertise will be invaluable in ensuring the accuracy of your blueprint!

Play 6: Continuously Review and Iterate

Building on the foundation laid in preceding steps, now it is time to emphasize the importance of continuous review and iteration for refining and enhancing your service blueprint. This ongoing cycle connects back to the stakeholder-driven foundation, ensuring that the blueprint evolves in harmony with user expectations and requirements. Here we focus on regular reviews, user feedback, and provide an optional Agile approach for those who find it suitable for their project characteristics.

Checklist:

- ☐ Schedule regular reviews with stakeholders to assess progress and make adjustments
- ☐ Actively seek feedback from target users to validate blueprint accuracy, usability, and effectiveness

Agile approach:

For blueprinting projects that involve a broad range of stakeholders, a complex domain area, and potentially evolving requirements, incorporating an Agile approach can help manage scope and priority.

- ☐ Break down blueprint creation into 1-2 week design sprints, setting clear objectives and goals
- ☐ Maintain a dynamic product backlog to capture feedback, enhancements, and user suggestions
- ☐ Conduct sprint demos after each design sprint to share progress and gather feedback

Key Questions:

- How will you schedule and conduct regular reviews with stakeholders?
- What methods will you use to actively seek and incorporate user feedback?
- If considering an Agile approach:
- How will design sprints be structured, and what goals will they aim to achieve?
- How will you manage and prioritize tasks in the product backlog?
- What is the plan for conducting sprint demos and incorporating feedback?

Tips & Resources:

1. For regular reviews, ensure alignment with stakeholders and keep them engaged in the blueprinting process.
2. Actively seek diverse user feedback channels to gain comprehensive insights.
3. If adopting an Agile approach, consider frameworks like Scrum or Kanban for structured planning. Remember, the blueprint is a living document, and its evolution is driven by continuous improvement and user-centric enhancements

RESOURCES:

Definitions & Key Concepts

Experience Catalog: Collection of service blueprints

Service blueprint: Visual diagram depicting the interrelationships among various service components

Service design: Holistic approach to creating and improving services that considers the entire user experience. It encompasses various elements, including user research, journey mapping, prototyping, and user testing.

Playbook: Series of recommended steps, questions, and tips drawn from research and iterative development

User actions: Steps, choices, activities, and interactions that customers perform while interacting with a service to reach a particular goal

Frontstage actions: Actions that occur directly in view of the customer

Backstage actions: Actions that occur outside of the customer's direct view

Product Owner Checklist

In the world of service blueprinting, a dedicated Product Owner plays a pivotal role in charting the course for success. This checklist outlines the key responsibilities and practices essential for effective product ownership, helping to ensure that your service blueprinting project remains on track and delivers valuable results.

Knowledge & Expertise

- ☐ Does your Product Owner have a good understanding of this CX domain, including user workflows and supporting systems?

Availability

- ☐ Is your Product Owner available at least once a week to help prioritize the backlog and approve key decisions?
- ☐ Is your Product Owner available to join your daily standup meeting? If not, is there someone who can represent them and make decisions on priorities?

Decision Making

- ☐ Does your Product Owner have the authority to make final decisions on priorities and features?

Stakeholder Engagement

- ☐ Is your Product Owner able to actively engage with SMEs/key stakeholders across VA to help gather feedback and requirements?
- ☐ Is your Product Owner available to attend regular demos to ensure accurate alignment and direction?